

The background of the cover features a stylized, high-contrast illustration. On the right side, a large, gnarled tree trunk with dense foliage extends from the top to the bottom. In the center, a body of water is depicted with horizontal brushstrokes, and a small boat is visible in the distance. The sky is a solid yellow-orange color with a few small, dark birds flying. The overall style is reminiscent of mid-20th-century graphic design.

the
Death
of the
Scharnhorst
and other poems

Arch Alfred
McKILLEN

The background of the cover is a textured, painterly illustration. It features a large, gnarled tree trunk on the right side, with a small boat or structure partially visible at its base. The sky is a mix of yellow and orange, with a few small birds flying. The water or ground below is depicted with dark, swirling lines. The overall style is reminiscent of mid-20th-century book cover art.

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Title: The Death of the Scharnhorst, and Other Poems

Author: Arch Alfred McKillen

Release date: February 19, 2021 [eBook #64594]

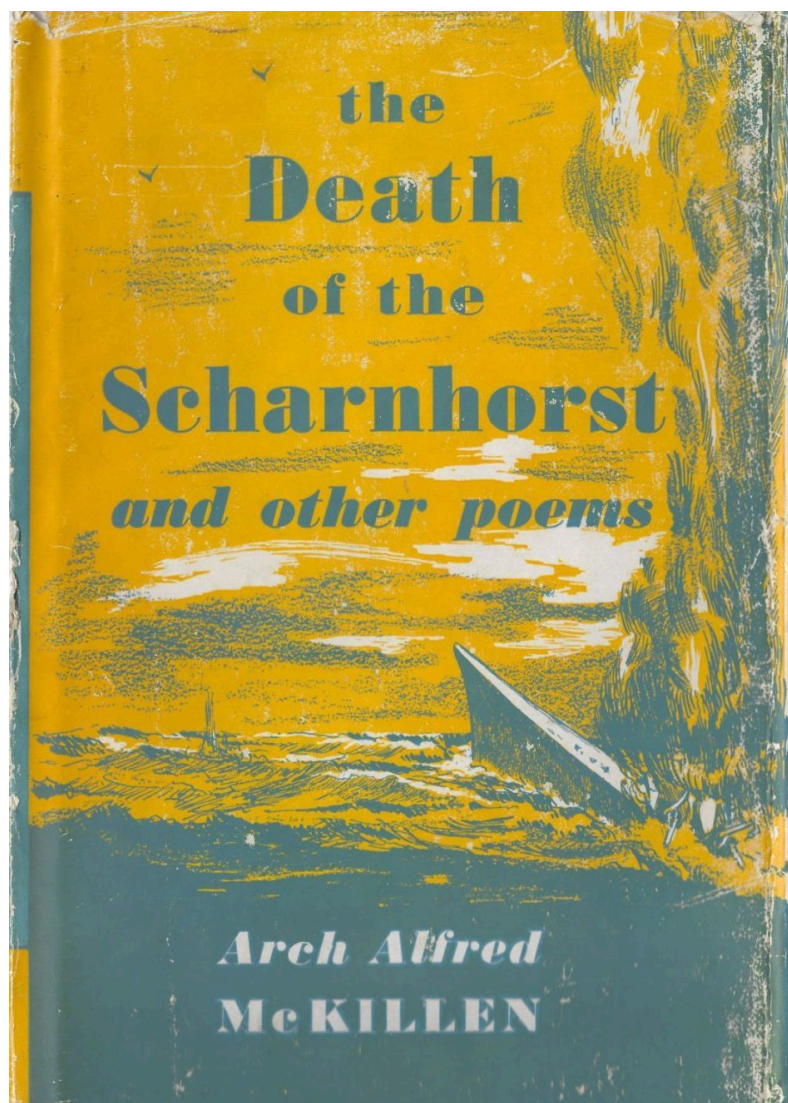
Most recently updated: October 18, 2024

Language: English

Other information and formats: www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/64594

Credits: Curt Troutwine, Mary Glenn Krause, Chuck Greif and the
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<https://www.pgdp.net>

*** START OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK THE DEATH OF
THE SCHARNHORST, AND OTHER POEMS ***



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THE DEATH
OF THE
SCHARNHORST
And Other Poems

by

Arch Alfred McKillen

In the powerful narrative poem which furnishes the title for this impressive first volume, Arch Alfred McKillen tells the dramatic story of the sinking of the German battleship *Scharnhorst*, during World War II—an important day for the Allied Forces.

These poems could have been written only by a man who has experienced deeply the emotions of which he writes. War is not the only subject of Mr. McKillen's poems. He writes of love; and indignation prompts him to write strongly against racial prejudice. Sharpness and simplicity of style contribute greatly to the forceful effects which he achieves. Too often a reader's enjoyment of poetry is marred by obscurity of meaning, but the clarity of thought and euphony of expression of the author, in this volume, leave no doubt in the reader's mind of his intent.

Reading THE DEATH OF THE SCHARNHORST AND OTHER POEMS will be a memorable experience for poetry lovers.

A
VANTAGE
BOOK

For
Remembrance
17 Dec 41
Arch McKillen

THE DEATH OF THE SCHARNHORST

AND OTHER POEMS

by ARCH ALFRED McKILLEN



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To
L.R.D., EM 1/c, U. S. Navy
Killed in action, Pearl Harbor, T. H.
December 7, 1941

*Smile a little, lad,
For when you smile
There is no sleep.
How can there then be Death?*

The Chicago *Sun* has kindly granted permission to
reprint the poem "The Litany of Pearl Harbor,"

which it published on December 7, 1942, in
June Provines' column

CONTENTS

	<i>Page</i>
The Bird, the Lad and Me	1
The War in Spain	1
It Rains Tonight	2
While Drums Are Rolling	2
Apollo	3
Fountain of Loveliness	4
Highway Number 66	5
Dirge for the <i>Squalus</i>	6
Echo Canyon	7
Fragment	8
We Hang upon a Scaffold	8
I Looked into Your Eyes	9
Of This Great Voiceless Love	9
I Would Have Brought You Fire	10
Too Much of Life	10
Lone Cello	11
Apocalypse	11
The Old Sea Wall	12
The Midnight Horseman	13
Lonely Heart	14
Dreams	15
The Bugles Called	15
Morning Guard	16
When Kilmer Wrote of Trees	17
Wild Geese	17
I Write to You in Red	18
'Tis Winter Now	18
Sonnet	19
The Tropic Dawn	20
Twilight	21

Echo	21
Star Course	22
Memorandum	23
The Litany of Pearl Harbor	23
We Were Waiting That Morning for Colors	26
The Motor Launch Crew	27
To the Garrison at Wake	28
Corregidor and Calvary	31
<i>When he and I had met</i>	33
To the Marines	34
The Lads Who Go Below	35
The Road to High Wood	36
Night Watch	37
The Soldier and the Samovar	38
Nocturne	38
The Swing	39
Somewhere on Leave	40
The Sentry	41
I Watched Him in the Tournament	41
South Pacific	42
Deck-Ape	43
Sailor Boy	43
Avenge	44
The Crossing of the Rhine	45
The Ballad of the Dead Sailor	45
The Death of the <i>Scharnhorst</i>	47
Little Boys and Little Dogs	53
<i>U.S.S. Oklahoma</i> Returns to Her Crew	54
Night	56
For All Heroes	57
Foxhole	58
Bury Him	61

THE BIRD, THE LAD AND ME

The sky was touched with tints of morn,
A wind was in the trees,
I lay in bed awakened
By the murmur of the leaves.

I listened to the chirping
Of the first-awakened bird,
And, his leather heels a-clicking,
Some lad off to work I heard.

Then my thoughts to sleep returning
Wondered briefly, of us three,
What brave paths the fates have destined
For the bird, the lad and me.

THE WAR IN SPAIN

The war in Spain is over
Yet victory does not smile
For all the lads are murdered
Who might have laughed awhile.

And those who march triumphant
Are sadder than the dead
Because their hearts are shadowed,
Because their hands are red.

The war in Spain is over,
Yet other trumpets sound
And call the world's young manhood
To another battleground.

IT RAINS TONIGHT

It rains tonight and wolf-winds howl.
His grave is not so deep,
But that the mournful Heavens
Upon his body weep;
They wet the mound of spaded earth
And through his coffin seep.

It rains tonight and wolf-winds howl,
And beaten hangs the tree,
And comfortless in Death he lies
Who comforted should be,
The guy who lost
 And killed himself,
 And never spoke to me!

WHILE DRUMS ARE ROLLING

Then you'll go while drums are rolling,
And you'll charge and make the bluff
That your heart is full of courage,
And you'll curse the vilest stuff.

And you'll see a lot of fellows
That you've never seen before,
And they may all be twenty
Or one or two years more.

And you'll briefly talk together,
But of what you will not know.
There is so much that lads can say
When off to war they go.

And you'll see a lot of fellows
When the battle roar is done,
Though all are dead upon the field
And will not know it's won.

And the drums will roll on, rolling
Till some bullet finds your heart,
Then you'll join the lads before you
And you'll never have to part.

APOLLO

Beautiful pagan, possess me!
Over thy body my fingers I race.
Hot on thy cheeks are my kisses,
Naked with thee in a lovers' embrace.

Passionate night,
And the scents from the orchard
Heavily here
 In thy temple retreat.

Moonlight and marble,
 Where pillars and shadows
Cast thee in twilight,

 Beautiful statue,
 Warm with the warmth
 Of my body
 Against thee,

I quiver,
 I clasp thee
 And fall at thy feet!

FOUNTAIN OF LOVELINESS

Fountain of loveliness, flowing
Deep in a wildwood of aspen and pine,
Swanlike forever upon thy calm surface
I drift in my nakedness, white in the sun.

O plunge me beneath,
Where thy depths are the greenest,
Cover my heart,
And the secret it keeps!

HIGHWAY NUMBER 66

We drove down the road
Like two bats out of Hell,
And before us the gates
At the rail crossing fell.

But we crashed through the splinters
And over the tracks,
And the train whistled madly
And screamed at our backs.

And we rode on in silence
With never a word,
And only the wind
And the motor were heard.

For a lad lay a-dying
That both of us knew,
And over the hills
To his bedside we flew.

He was dead when we got there,
And somehow I know
At that curve on the hill
With the valley below,

Where the crossing is laid,
And that monster of steel,
Not my hand, but his
Was guiding the wheel.

DIRGE FOR THE SQUALUS

We did not raise a submarine
From the ocean's fathomed bed,
But twenty-six brave sailor lads
And all of them were dead.
We left them not beneath the sea;
We brought them sadly home,
To dedicate anew to Death,
Who nevermore shall roam.

Then, trumpeter, be firm your lip,
What though the tears may fall,
For muffled drums in velvet beat
Beneath your trumpet's call.
And there are hearts in other lads
That swell with sorrow, too.
It need not matter that those hearts
Are not in navy blue.

And they who have escaped that tomb
Beneath the restless wave,
How deeply reverent they hold
The gift the dead men gave.
For twenty-six on them bestowed
The utmost they could give,
When twenty-six accepted death
That thirty-three might live.

The passage doorway dogged and tight,
On either side two groups of men.
In one compartment, mad with fright,
The thirty-three who'll live again.
And on the other, maddened, too,
The water rising swiftly, high,
The twenty-six who looked and knew
They were the ones who had to die.

Then let some fitting tribute stand
When we from here are fled

When we from here are dead,
The living consecrated
By the consecrated dead!

ECHO CANYON

We ride to Echo Canyon,
He rides with me tonight,
No moon above to guide us,
The stars alone are bright.

The wind is in the sagebrush;
Somewhere a coyote calls;
The studded sky is briefly lit
As a flaming starlet falls.

We draw the rein together,
He trembles as I pass
To turn the horses free to graze
In the wild September grass.

And now I stretch beside him
Where he lies upon the ground,
And in all this lovely wilderness
We two alone are found.

FRAGMENT

He wandered through the darkened streets of night,
His massive cape a-blown with every wind.
He passed the strumpets flirting near the lamps,
And bowed to one—the one most infamous.
Then down familiar avenues he strolled,
And met, as he was sure to meet them there,
The lads who knew these lanes where men were bold.

How many a British soldier went to death
Beneath an Afric sun with some small gift,
A pocketknife inlaid with precious stones,
A case for cigarettes, or watch and chain,
Which had been given him by Oscar Wilde.

WE HANG UPON A SCAFFOLD

We hang upon a scaffold, lad,
The skeleton within
Is all the horror of the world,
Of virtue and of sin.

For he who knows no word of love,
Nor has his heart's desire,
Must hang the same and die the same
As he who walks in fire.

Then hang upon your scaffold, lad
The mob will pierce your side,
Yet cry your triumph and your pain,
For man is crucified.

I LOOKED INTO YOUR EYES

I looked into your eyes and saw,
Or thought I saw, your love.
I tried to hide my own from you;
Not ever spoken of.

Yet, there was something I could feel
Electrify the air
When both of us were quite alone
And no one else was there.

And when at last I spoke my love,
And wanting yours for me,
I looked into your eyes and knew
Such love was not to be.

OF THIS GREAT VOICELESS LOVE

Of this great voiceless love of mine for you
There is no word to your heart out of mine
That may go winging through the whispering night.

Look only then for laughter in my letters
As I from day to day *The Fool* rehearse.
And if one blushing phrase too boldly written
Inscribes too fervently that I am yours,
Believe it only penmanship and style,
Or the careless informality of friends.

I WOULD HAVE BROUGHT YOU FIRE

I would have brought you fire for those nights
When you were cold and lonely and in doubt.
I would have brought you laughter for your tears
And given you new dreams to dream about.

But look away, your eyes are much too bright,
And sorrow has lent beauty to your face,
And should I cast aside this cloak of years
And live forever after in disgrace—
It is an old temptation sprung anew,
 Yet must not be.
Ah, look at me and you shall see
I am, my love, as miserable as you!

TOO MUCH OF LIFE

Too much of life we spend alone,
Too many thoughts are ours to share,
Too little love we call our own
Though multitudes of men are there.

We're strangers undetermined of
Where madness rules the lives of men,
Where he who dares design of love
Lives not to dare the deed again.

Beware of love! Be lonely, lad.
There is no death that can compare
Where loving hearts are crucified,
And multitudes of men are there.

LONE CELLO

Too much is incomplete. Let's make an end
Of all the fond impossible dreams we've dreamed,
And when we part,
We were not meant to be
Too closely here companioned where the thorn
Of our red love transfixes joy's brief crown.
The roses wither, time itself decays,
And log-lit embers fall to ashes when
The memory of the flame no longer glows.

We rode to Echo Canyon and your smile
Ran naked through the chambers of my heart.
Now lonely cellos must out parting sing
As when some cool green afternoon lets fall
From one high branch a few wind-weary leaves.
We grow too old too suddenly. Farewell!

APOCALYPSE

These are the seeds of the future,
The weary, the wretched, the slain.
These are the ghosts we shall harvest
In wars that shall come again.

These are the fields we have furrowed,
The dreams that have fallen apart,
And this is the plow of our madness,
The fear that has entered the heart.

Oh, how shall we welcome the reaper
When autumn shall fill the air,
When all the hope of the springtime
Is cut with the edge of despair?

THE OLD SEA WALL

Oh, you who go hurrying, worrying by
With never a cry or a call,
Saw you a lad who was standing here
On the crest of the old sea wall?

I saw him last night in the twilight
As the long low breakers rolled,
And across the bay in the chapel
An evening bell was tolled.

And we looked at each other a moment
And then from each other we turned,
But I read in his eyes of a longing
That a merciless world had spurned.

Oh, have you no answer to make me,
All you who go hastening past,
And though I am late will none tell me
Where he was standing last?

Like a whisper I hear from the sea wall,
Where the waters are troubled below,
A murmur of wavelets complaining,
And the fate of the lad I know.

Spin onward, old world, to your ending.
The hearts that you break and condemn
Will someday rise madly against you,
Reversing your judgment of them.

THE MIDNIGHT HORSEMAN

Ten thousand trees in the forest stood
And watched me as I passed,
Ten thousand trees that did not breathe
The wind that rode as fast,
Ten thousand leaves on every tree
Immovably aghast!

The road in the light of the moon was white,
The sky overhead was gray,
With a kind of a washed, half-tone effect
That took the night away,
Yet to right and left like the cloak of death
The deepest darkness lay.

The steed's quick breath his hooves beat out
And silvered all the air,
On, on we sped like a thing of dread;
We were a ghostly pair.
We passed the somber stricken wood;
We found no shelter there.

I might have stayed and made pretense
That I was like the rest,
And laughed and drunk and sung their songs
As loudly as the best,
And never have given an answer to,
Not recognized my quest.

Farewell, and onward! Piteous flight
That leaves all friends behind,
That hastes from old familiar scenes
Where love was young and kind.
Oh, petrified Sylvania,
Where shall I others find?

LONELY HEART

Where do you wander far and afield,
Lonely heart? Lonely heart, where is your shield?

Where are your rings and where is your purse?
Love is expensive. It's cheaper to curse.

Where are your garments? Look at your shoes.
Laughter or sorrow, which did you choose?

Walking the streets, nights that are cold,
Men who are wretched, men who are bold.

Rooms in the shadows, Love me tonight,
Love me and leave me before it grows bright.

Don't heed the sob of a heartbreak within.
Hold me, and kiss me and teach me to sin!

Into the quicksand, hungry and dark,
Into the grotto, into the park,
Into the depths of the tomb, it is said,
Lovers have cast themselves, living and dead.

Lonely heart, lonely heart, walking alone,
Friendless and frantic, and turning to stone!

DREAMS

If you've a dream at heart, lad,
Some wilfull, noble plan,
Then cherish it within, lad,
And tell it to no man.

To friend and foe alike be dumb
On what you plan to do,
And keep that secret chamber locked
Until the work is through.

For I had dreams at heart, boy,
But talked them all away,
And now I needs must start, boy,
To dream anew today.

THE BUGLES CALLED

We lay together, he and I,
Upon a little hill,
Beneath a tree that sheltered us,
As trees so often will.

I touched his hand and felt him stir,
Expectancy of love!
And then my lips poured out my heart,
The things I told him of.

But when his heart began to speak
The bugles called to war
And he arose and left me there.
I never saw him more.

MORNING GUARD

Where the old road meets the new road
I stand the guard at morn,
Where one comes winding down the hill,
The other, through it torn.

October's friendly fingers dipped
In every mellow shade
Have touched the leaves on all the trees
That stand within the glade.

In distant treetops I behold,
As I have seen in clouds,
The faces of my heroes
Or dead men in their shrouds.

The marching columns pass me by,
All sailor lads in blue.
And some will wink, and some will smile,
The way young fellows do.

And overhead the deepening sky
More bright and bluer flows,
While one lone fleecy, sheeplike cloud
Before the dog-wind goes.

The restless leaves like pounding surf
Sound breakers through the trees.
I strip of all reality
And drown myself in these.

WHEN KILMER WROTE OF TREES

When Kilmer wrote of trees he must have seen
The flowering catalpas all a-bloom,
And though about him guns spoke quick of death
And distant cannon thundered oaths of doom
He did not harken. What were all of these
To where beyond the trenches stood the trees?

WILD GEESE

Geese in the night flying low,
I hear the beat of their wings.
I wish that I could know
If they are calling to me.

Rain and a wintry wind
And trees that have shed their leaf.
If man at first had not sinned
Then Christ had not been born.

I WRITE TO YOU IN RED

I write to you in red, though not in blood,
For scarlet all my memories are dyed
With deep imaginings of what the past,
The past, the past—the unforgotten gone.
Ah, what it might have been designed upon!

I write to you in red because the flood
Of scarlet passion prisoned, long denied
Your love, yet in your bondage bonded fast,
Is freed to flow again, to stream,
And if it can, another love esteem.

But all too long your chains upon my heart
Have left a scar which testifies me dead
To all frivolity. I have no part
With lightsome love.
I write to you in red!

'TIS WINTER NOW

When spring again revisits earth,
And in the dark there comes a stirreth
Of seedlings bursting with the birth
Of summer's future flowers,
 Then will I sing you songs of love
 And apple blossoms branched above
 Shall know the dear devotion of
 My poor poetic powers.

But wait till then—'tis winter now.
My thoughts in solitude are claimed.
Yet every wind shall hear my vow
Repeated through the hours,
 It's you alone I love,
 And unashamed.

SONNET

Like solitary mountain peaks that list
And seem to sink in seas of restless grain
My love for you goes drowning through a mist
Of unrequited, unrecorded pain.

Oh, while there's breath of life and passion still,
While yet remains a warmth, a failing flame
Within the fallen fortress of my will,
Give me a moment of your love to claim.

Come let me hold you close in hushed embrace
And crush you with the force of fierce desire,
Yet by that love no future plan to trace,
But just to love that moment to conspire.

I will not chain you, though enchained by thee;
The memory of your love will prison me.

THE TROPIC DAWN

The tropic dawn is beautiful at sea,
The clouds respond so readily to light.
Though overhead the stars continue bright
And scattered like a broken string of beads,
The eastward doors of night are opened wide
And light floods all the ocean floor inside.

The sun gets up, a painter out of bed,
To work again his canvas of the world,
To change black water into blue instead,
To tint what little frantic foam gets hurled
From two waves' temperaments with ruby fire,
And make the sea a thing for man's desire.

The day comes gently, working through the clouds,
Which light and burn with brilliance many-hued.
A sailor somewhere singing in the shrouds
With naked chest and feet and arms tatooed,
His sailor hat at angle on his head,
Salutes the day with thoughts of home and bed.

Oh, take me back, away from dawn and sea,
Oh, take me where the heart of me would be,
And in some blessed meadow set me free!

TWILIGHT

A little while ago that sky was gold,
And green that hill,
And blue the white-capped sea,
And I stood watching through these vines a ship
That moved, hull down, beyond,
Beneath the point.

I wonder now, before the stars are out
And long black clouds have filled the sunset sky,
Will I remember this at midnight hour:
 How much I longed to be aboard that ship!

ECHO

Oh, weary heart, dependent for a song
On whether someone smiles or not at thee.
Oh, weary life, the loveless years are long
Yet deathless are the thoughts of him to me.

Within an ancient castle on the coast,
Where all the sea-dead sailor lads make moan,
I hear a melancholy cello sing
Its mad and mournful music to the moon,
A dirge of febrile beauty and despair
That fills the night with phantom, frantic song.

And phrase to phrase with sexual life responds
While fierce satyriasis, orchestrally,
Like nine symphonic horns unharmonized
Calls wildly through the hollows of my heart.

STAR COURSE

Into the darkening east we ride,
Wave upon wave we thrust aside,
White and defiant they seethe around.
What do we care! We're homeward bound!

The sea beneath and the sky above,
These are the things a man can love,
Not when he leaves his native shore,
But when, far out of the sight of land,
He takes the wheel with a steady hand
To guide him home once more.

Then homeward, homeward be my course,
And constant be my star,
For I have wandered east and west
And I have wandered far,
Yet home and joy can only be
Where love and friendship are.

I've searched among the isles of men
The love I left behind,
Explored for friendships in the waste
Of broken, humankind,
And sought for beauty, sought for wit,
With naught of all to find.

In dens of laughter when I laughed
There came a hollow sound,
Yet every night I went again
To join the merry round,
And every night I knew that there
My heart would not be found.

Then homeward, homeward be my course,
And constant be my star,
And may I not have changed too much
Because I've wandered far.
Their love and laughter now I need

Who home and friendship are.

MEMORANDUM

Quick are the sands that bury a man
When he lays him down to die,
And quick are the hands if there be no sands
Of such fellows as you and I.

THE LITANY OF PEARL HARBOR

Harbor of morning,
Day has begun.
Hills of Oahu
Are waiting the sun.

Harbor of reveille,
Hammocks away.
Sailors are stirring
On ships in the bay.

Harbor of happiness,
Green and complete.
Day from the summit
Has smiled on the fleet.

Harbor deceived,
Death in the sky
Plummets to earth
Before colors shall fly.

Harbor surprised,
Torpedo and shell
Tear through the living,
Harbor of Hell!

Harbor of terror,
Harbor of death,
Harbor where fellows
Are choking for breath.

Harbor of drownings,
Thunderous sound.
Flooded compartments
Harbor the drowned.

Harbor of fire,
Harbor of flame,
Steel and humanity

Crumble the same.

Harbor determined,
Stations are manned.
Against the aggressor
The Harbor will stand.

Harbor of courage,
Gunners and guns
Speak of the worth
Of America's sons.

Harbor of shipmates,
Sanctified flood,
Dying together,
Harbor of blood!

Harbor of wounds,
Beneath the attack,
Fighting the enemy,
Driving him back.

Harbor of smoke,
Blinding the sun.
Harbor contested,
Yet to be won.

Harbor of roaring,
Harbor ablaze,
Harbor of horror,
Harbor of praise.

Harbor resurgent,
Out of the gloom,
Self-resurrected
Out of the tomb.

Glorious Harbor,
Harbor of woe,

Harbor of vengeance
Blasting the foe.

Harbor of hours,
Endless, intense,
Harbor victorious,
Epic defense.

Dedicate Harbor,
Shipmates are there
Sleeping forever.
Harbor of prayer.

WE WERE WAITING THAT MORNING FOR COLORS

We were waiting that morning for colors,
And the bands were ready to play,
And a motor launch crossing the harbor
Was making its peaceful way,
But to war and the roar of its thunder
Old Glory went up that day.

The firmament split, and our gunners,
The bravest and handsomest crew,
Mid fiery bomb and shrapnel,
Oh, how to their stations they flew!

They fought like a legion of angels
Against the corruption of Hell,
In the blaze of a sacred vengeance
For shipmate lads who fell.

They fought off the vicious invader,
They cut him out of the air,
And he dropped through the smoke of the combat
To death and destruction there.

And our flag through the hours of battle
Flew on till the fighting was won.
Oh, beautiful, dedicate banner,
Our victory has only begun.

With such gunners as ours to defend you,
So bright and beloved in the sky,
While devotion and manhood attend you,
Brave standard, continue on high.
We were waiting that morning for colors.
Old Glory forever shall fly!

THE MOTOR LAUNCH CREW

Crossing the harbor, four lads in a motor launch
Saw the invader host drop from the sky,
Saw a torpedo's white wake through the water
Make for the stern of a vessel nearby.

"Jump!" cried the coxswain, "Here is my duty,
Here is the logic for which I was born,
One life asunder to stop the torpedo
Ere from their bodies a hundred are torn!"

"Nay," cried the bowman. "We're in this together.
Glory to God and such men as ye are!"
Seizing a boat hook he jumped to the gunwhale,
As mad as old Ahab, as fixed as a star.

Oh, the wild race in the harbor that morning!
Prayed to his Diesel the kid engineer,
"Fail me not now, O my beautiful engine!"
Swiftly the launch and torpedo drew near.

Wake upon wake, the two masses converging,
Never a word by the sternman was said.
Oh, there was death in the harbor that morning!
Under the keel the torpedo shaft fled.

Then with the force of a mighty harpooner,
Melville's dread hero, such bowman was he,
Then from his arm the long boat hook went plunging
Faster than death and destruction could flee.

Into the blades of the whirling propeller,
Following after, the iron hook sank,
Changing the mark where the war head exploded,
Tumbling the rocks and a tree from the bank.

Then all around them the harbor was seething,
Concussion and fire and shouting and fear,
And they, too, are dead. Dead that motor launch coxswain,

That bowman, and sternman and kid engineer!

TO THE GARRISON AT WAKE

A little while, O sacramental dead,
Unvisited a little while yet be.
You shall not lie forgotten nor alone
While ships there are, and planes, and guns, and men.
For now, more adamant, more fierce, more keen,
In permanence and purpose fixed as stars,
To finite manhood hereby we annex
The infinite almightiness of God,
And we shall be His judgment! Woe to that
Ambitious offal sprung from Hell's abyss
Which catastrophically we shall destroy,
Annihilate, forever make extinct.

No evil feet, where from your chaliced hearts
The precious blood has spilled, shall tread that earth,
That holy, transubstantiated isle
Whose very soil is body, soul, and blood
Of restless lads who loved America!
On who so tread shall light and darkness pounce,
Vast winged horrors plummeting, destroy,
Consuming brilliance, glut-engulfing night,
Like twin devourers, feed there on them!

Ye ancient dead, who fell with Greece or Rome,
Or in the name of Allah and his prophet,
Who fell through all the cycled years of war,
Through plague, disaster, fell in civil strife,
Through revolution, famine, flood and fire,
Apocalyptic woe or freezing night,
Ye ancient dead, to whom heroic stance
And unsundered dignity still cling,
Receive who come among you now like gods,
Four hundred splendid, handsome, golden lads.
To them extend that comradeship of men
Who live the rugged military life,
Who smile that full, good-natured kind of smile,
Most boyishly unstudied, most beloved,

~~~~~



Who know each other's thoughts and wants and hopes,  
Who know what prayers are said and what forgot,  
Who know that greatest, crucifying love  
Where friends for friends on strange new crosses die!

And you, O Seraph Outpost Garrison,  
Who side by side heroically made stand,  
No quarter given, none received, none asked,  
Who fought those vicious legions in the three  
Old elemental spheres, and of the fourth,  
Almost invincible to flame and death,  
Stood firmly placed before, beneath the attack  
Like Milton's epic host against all Hell,  
New rest, brave lads, in consecrated sleep,  
While lonely trumpets sing through muffled drums  
A requiem and threnody of grief.

Ah, great Cecilia, Bach, and Handel blind,  
Those last full-throated notes to swell from earth,  
That trumpet song of loneliness and night,  
Give it a contrapuntal theme beneath,  
Whose pedal harmonies orchestrally  
Shall hint of resurrection, while the pipes  
And organ-pillar'd flutes resound the mode  
To which the ancient dead have matched and sung.

Then light the strings until they burn as bright  
And numberless as candles round a shrine,  
Then start the rolling drums, and set the brass  
Canonically recalling one another,  
And let the reeds' ancestral wisdom speak,  
What though at first the grave bassoons must weep  
Their melancholy, febrile lamentation.  
Unsheathe the horns and cut the harmonic knot.  
Let full grand orchestra astound the void  
With soaring fugue and metric tympani.

And in this last, let herald trumpets sing  
While bright kid-trumpeteers who fell at Pearl

Resound a call to quarters there beyond!

*CORREGIDOR AND CALVARY*

Corregidor and Calvary,  
And Christ again is crucified,  
And all the lovely lads who died  
Are His this day in Paradise.

They hung upon a wretched cross,  
We watched them day by day,  
And wondered how such men could live  
Who hung in such a way,  
Who hung in thorns of screeching steel  
And had no time to pray.

We knew that soon the lads must die,  
And yet they battled death  
Unmindful of his awful wings  
And black, consuming breath,  
Unmindful when he roared at them  
Or whispered what he saith.

For shattered men will die in pain,  
And shaken men will weep,  
And there are things which blast the blood  
And through the body creep,  
And men will not lie down at night  
Afeared that they will sleep.

Afeared they would too deeply sleep,  
That battered hearts would burst;  
And though each knew that he must die,  
The dawn must beckon first,  
And each must feel again the grip  
Of loneliness and thirst.

For none would die alone, apart,  
By twos and twelves they fell,  
And if a man could walk he worked,  
He loaded shot and shell,  
For none would die alone. anart.

Within a narrow cell.

Within a narrow cell at last  
All men someday must lie,  
But while their blood was in the heart  
And light within the eye,  
They would not leave the stand they took  
Beneath the open sky.

They would not leave us, watching them,  
Examples of defeat,  
That when we come to look on death,  
And though our ranks deplete,  
Somehow we must think back to them,  
The way they met it, meet!

*Alas, Love, I would thou couldst as well  
defende thy selfe as thou canst offende others*  
—SIR PHILIP SIDNEY

When he and I had met I knew  
The way he smiled at me  
That we'd become the best of pals  
Two guys could ever be.

For night and day he filled my thoughts,  
I talked of only him,  
But there were eyes which watched us both,  
Suspicious, cold, and dim.

Suspicious eyes and little mouths  
That each reporting made  
Of all the times we went to swim  
Or rested in the shade.

They told of how we'd taken horse  
To ride about the lea,  
And how two lonely mounts were seen  
Beneath a rugged tree.

They gossiped how instead of church  
We went to watch the sun  
Come charging over purple hills  
To see the day begun,  
And how we came not home again  
Until that day was done.

And he and I went off to war,  
Yet still their evil fed.  
He never knew, not ever will,  
The wretched things they said,  
For he was on Corregidor,  
And now the lad is dead.

## *TO THE MARINES*

There's only one banner says "Semper Fidelis!"  
There's only one flag we defend,  
There's only one heart and one mind and one body  
In all of our battles we send.

We fought and we bled on Bataan and Corregidor,  
Oh, how we held them at Wake!  
And waited in vain for more men and munitions  
With all the Pacific at stake.

The sleepers were many, but we were the few  
Who wakened the quickest and fought,  
And while readjustment and training were planned,  
We did what we could, what we ought.

Our dead are at Henderson. Think you they rest?  
They fight even now at our side,  
Refusing to enter the realms of the blest  
Until we have beaten the tide!

*THE LADS WHO GO BELOW*

The enemy's reported,  
And he'd like to see the show,  
But he handles ammunition  
So he's got to go below.

And he's ready on his station,  
Every nerve alert and keen,  
With a group of grim-faced sailors  
In a lower magazine.

They can feel the ship's vibrations  
When the broadside salvos go,  
And the shatter of the turrets  
When they batter at the foe.

"Send 'em up and keep 'em coming!  
Man the phones and man the hoist!"  
Sweat and curse and pass the powder  
Till the very deck is moist.

But the enemy is daring,  
And his planes get through the screen,  
A torpedo rips the blister  
Just above the magazine.

Water fills the whole compartment,  
In another fires rage,  
But the guns still get their powder  
And the enemy engage.

Trapped below, the lads are living,  
And the hungry hoist they feed,  
Though the first concussion stunned them  
And their deafened ears must bleed.

Other hits, the foeman scoring,  
Thunderous roars of flaming sheen,  
"Save the ship from an explosion,



Flood the lower magazine!”

Lads, farewell! The air was dirty  
With a lot of fume and smoke,  
It’s as bad, lads, when you smother  
As on briny water choke.

But the enemy’s defeated,  
Thanks to you who’ll never know,  
You who handled ammunition  
And who had to go below!

### *THE ROAD TO HIGH WOOD*

It was on the road to High Wood  
That we found him lying dead,  
The soldier boy in khaki  
With the broken, battered head.

No more at dawn or sunset  
Will he hear the bugle note,  
Nor thrill to taps ascending  
From a trumpet’s silver throat.

It was on the road to High Wood  
Where the maple leaves were burned  
That the lad went out at morning  
And nevermore returned.

There are many roads to High Wood,  
There are many roads to Hell,  
And the fields of wheat are rotten  
Where a thousand heroes fell.

## *NIGHT WATCH*

His ship is on the ocean  
But the sailor lad's ashore,  
And deeply, deeply sleeping,  
He'll waken nevermore.

We buried him atop the hill  
That overlooks the bay,  
And one there was who walked from there  
With slower steps away.

And one there is on watch at night  
Who wears the strangest smile,  
Because he sees a specter lad  
And talks with him awhile.

Across the world he comes to me,  
And far horizons dim,  
And I await the day when I,  
Instead, shall go to him.

Then we will sail on all the seas  
That poets can recite,  
And stand beside another lad,  
And watch with him at night.

## *THE SOLDIER AND THE SAMOVAR*

They shot him as he left the house  
And stripped him in the snow  
But still he held the samovar  
And would not let it go.

Who knows from what fine home he came  
With afternoons at tea?  
If I had been that lonely lad,  
They would have shot at me.

For I'd have run as desperately  
Behind some log to settle,  
And sit me down beside my theft,  
The big, old Russian kettle.

But dead he lies; the snow piles high  
And winter fills the land,  
And only spring will move the thing  
And take it from his hand.

## *NOCTURNE*

Beside you while you slumbered, lad,  
My restless heart had lain  
Through all the hours of the night  
Aware of love and pain.

Aware of love and morning's light  
And eyes that must betray  
When someday you should look in mine  
Then ever look away.

I'll come to where you slumber, lad,  
If death shall mark me not  
And say the prayer that now I pray,  
And thought I had forgot.

## *THE SWING*

The crooked swing that hung beneath  
The crooked willow tree  
Brought all his laughter to my ears  
When school was out at three.

When later years and afternoons  
Their symphony had sung  
Beneath the crooked willow tree  
An idle swing had hung.

Then war came on. There's always war  
To readjust the past,  
And he got leave and I got leave,  
And home we came at last.

But I alone return tonight  
And naught to battle bring,  
For he is dead beneath the tree  
And broken hangs the swing.

## *SOMEWHERE ON LEAVE*

Unfurrowed field and lonely plow,  
The laughing lad has fled,  
Sweet-throated, unaccompanied lark,  
The laughing lad is dead.

I found him on a barren tract,  
Stretched out and lying still,  
And on his lips the blood had dried,  
And on the blasted hill.

Oh, that was far from hills like these,  
A hundred thousand guns  
Are booming, bursting in his ears  
And he does not hear a one.

A soldier's thoughts and a soldier's laugh  
And a soldier's boyish grin  
Are dead on a lonely battlefield,  
And the war is yet to win.

## *THE SENTRY*

The night wind hums a lullaby,  
A watchful bivouac keep.  
The guns are silent now awhile,  
Yet, soldier, do not sleep.  
Though weary with the force of night,  
And weary with the war,  
Sleep not, be watchful, quick alert,  
Or sleep forever more.

But words are nought to tired eyes,  
And what are words of praise  
To minds that long to dream a bit  
Of other, saner days.  
He sleeps, unmindful of his oath,  
And then they find him dead,  
The other soldier stands his guard  
Who shot him through the head.

The night wind hums a lullaby,  
A watchful bivouac keep.  
The guns are silent now awhile,  
Yet, soldier, do not sleep!

*I WATCHED HIM IN THE TOURNAMENT*

I watched him in the tournament,  
And when he bowled a line  
I saw the way his eyes would smile  
When things were going fine.

I saw the lonely little frown  
That made him look so grave  
And older than his twenty years  
When things would not behave.

And then we did not meet again;  
I heard that he was dead.  
The savage sea, not you nor me,  
Knows where he is instead.



*SOUTH PACIFIC*

How often had the sun been red  
The sky as deep a blue  
Behind long, tired stretched-out clouds  
When I was then with you.

How often had the evening sea  
Which you so much admired  
With archipelagos of foam  
Been bright and ruby-fired.

Oh, all these things tonight are here  
Upon a distant sea,  
But I have found no other one  
To stand and watch with me.

## *DECK-APE*

He was just a little deck-ape  
With a happy kind of smile,  
And a line of boyish chatter  
That could make you laugh awhile.

He was just a little deck-ape  
Always ready with a hand  
When a shipmate needed someone  
Who would help or understand.

He was just a little deck-ape,  
And we buried him at sea  
When he stopped a strafing's bullet  
That was meant, I think, for me.

## *SAILOR BOY*

Upon a railway station bench he lies,  
Majestic image of a heathen god  
Cast down unknown centuries of time,  
And on his back for all the world to see.

He sleeps the silence of unspoken love,  
A smile upon his lips, his cheeks aglow  
With all the fire of his rhythmic heart  
Betraying there the secret of his dream.

And breath and life are one where fills his chest,  
And where the texture of his thighs impress  
The pagan phallic frontlet in his loins  
He testifies unknowingly to youth.

Unstirring in the rapture of his thoughts  
He slumbers in the wakeful watch  
Of envy and desire!

## *AVENGE*

Avenge! Avenge! Great sword of God,  
The massacre of these  
Ten thousand Polish soldier lads,  
All hung from gallows' trees.

Send down Thy angels armed with fire,  
Send down Thy fiery lake,  
Avenge the tortured, fiercely marred,  
And killed for killing's sake,  
Brave prisoners of Guam, Bataan, Corregidor, and Wake!

O hasten, hasten, wrath of God!  
Five times five thousand slain  
In one red week of murderous lust,  
New Christs, new cross, new pain!

Our patience and our mercy wait  
While they who slaughter don't.  
Annihilate! Annihilate!  
We'll do it if You won't!

## *THE CROSSING OF THE RHINE*

And what is the talk we make tonight  
As we fill our glasses amber bright  
And drink to the guys who are in the fight,  
The crossing of the Rhine.

And the song we sing is a simple thing  
Of a tune that moves with a martial swing  
To a set of words that have caught the ring,  
The crossing of the Rhine.

We laugh and we jest, and we wish them well,  
And then we remember the lads who fell  
By blasted bridge and screaming shell,  
The crossing of the Rhine.

Let's stand as we pledge the guys who are there,  
The guys who are fighting everywhere  
Through blood and guts and the power of prayer,  
The crossing of the Rhine!

*THE BALLAD OF THE DEAD SAILOR*

Oh, where are the rest of my shipmates,  
And why am I not at sea,  
And what is this lonely valley  
Where no one is but me?

Have they sailed away without me?  
Will they ever again return?  
I never thought when he was dead  
A sailor's heart would yearn.

Oh, how did I die? In battle?  
Or how did I die? Asleep?  
Were there any who laughed when they heard it?  
Were any too stunned to weep?

But who dressed me up so neatly?  
Who brushed and combed my hair?  
Some fellow just doing his duty  
Or someone who tried to care?

Whoever it was I thank him,  
But what have they done to my heart  
That it will not rest like a lonesome guest  
In this world where they've set me apart?

Must I still call out for companions  
And want them again at my side,  
Though breath is forbidden me ever  
As the longing I want to confide?

O you who are shipmates together,  
Look well at each other today,  
Or you'll lie deep as I in your anguish,  
And pine your dead heart away.

*THE DEATH OF THE SCHARNHORST*



On Christmas Day in forty-three  
The Nazi *Scharnhorst* put to sea,  
For word somehow had reached Berlin  
An Allied convoy was within  
Two hundred miles of where she lay  
In some Norwegian, hidden bay.

She went ahead, two-thirds her speed,  
A mighty, master-monster steed,  
She left the fjords, mountain walled,  
Where oft her echoing bugles called,  
She cleared the channel, marked the land  
Drop far astern on either hand.

She steamed through fog and arctic day,  
And then at night, when darkness lay  
Completely over all the waste,  
The *Scharnhorst* charged with fuller haste  
To intercept the Allied ships  
Which dared these bold Murmansk-bound trips.

Meanwhile the convoy, slow, serene,  
Behind an escort naval screen,  
Proceeded eastward off North Cape.  
The *Scharnhorst* sensed the coming rape,  
And manned her guns that early dawn,  
But this is what she came upon:

The cruisers *Norfolk*, and *Belfast*,  
And *Sheffield*, all the long night past  
Had known the wild sea horse was free  
To terrorize the Northern Sea,  
And they had placed themselves between  
The charging *Scharnhorst* and the screen.

The winter's dawn was blackboard gray.  
The *Scharnhorst* held her plotted way.  
The *Norfolk*. *Sheffield*. and *Belfast*

Were tense with waiting. Hours passed  
As closer these two forces drew,  
Determined ships, determined crew.

The British sensed the approach of doom.  
The *Scharnhorst* paused within the gloom,  
But then a star shell, bursting high,  
Illumined her against the sky.  
The great seabeast began to snort  
From every nostril turret fort.

The *Sheffield's* guns belched smoke and flame;  
*Belfast's* quick turrets did the same,  
The *Norfolk's* screaming shell bursts bit  
The monster's triple hull, a hit!  
The *Scharnhorst* screamed, she turned and fled  
To mend her wound, to count her dead.

*Belfast* forbade his ships pursue.  
He judged what *Scharnhorst* meant to do,  
Pretend retreat and then renew  
Attack upon the convoy later.  
*Scharnhorst's* speed he knew was greater,  
So he kept his course the straighter.

*Scharnhorst* circled east and nor'ward,  
Hoped to bring her power forward.  
But the convoy changed its course  
To shun this grim, abhorrent horse.  
The cruisers cut the arc and then  
Awaited *Scharnhorst's* charge again.

When, hours later, tense with rage,  
The *Scharnhorst*, plotted to engage  
Just merchant ships and escort craft,  
Had reappeared to run the raft,  
She met instead the concerted blast  
Of *Norfolk*, *Sheffield* and *Belfast*.

Once again the salvos thundered.  
*Scharnhorst* knew that she had blundered,  
While her gunners cursed and wondered  
Shells and fire as before  
Through the gloomy twilight tore,  
Swiftly, surely, more and more.

The *Norfolk's* afterdeck was hit,  
A blaze of flame, the air was lit.  
The *Scharnhorst* did not wait to see  
What damage or what victory.  
She turned once more in fearful dread,  
Homeward set her course and fled.

For *Scharnhorst* was a worthy prize.  
Correctly had she made surmise  
That other ships, the British fleet,  
Would steam to intercept or meet,  
And so she fled, a wounded beast,  
To seek the dark, protective east.

But all this while, to interplace  
Between the *Scharnhorst* and her base,  
To cut the Nazi monster's course,  
To bridle all her vicious force,  
To leave a wreck of twisted torque,  
There steamed the mighty *Duke of York*.

Two hundred miles away or more  
The *Duke* and her destroyers bore  
When first the battle message came.  
*Belfast* continued to proclaim  
The *Scharnhorst's* course, and from this plot  
The *Duke*, her speed, position got.

For brave *Belfast*, and *Sheffield*, too,  
And *Norfolk* this time did pursue.  
The *Scharnhorst* turned, she headed south,

And flung herself into the mouth  
Of *Duke, Jamaica*, and the horde,  
*Saumarez, Savage, Scorpion, Stord*.

“Illuminate the enemy!”  
*Belfast*’s bright shell broke high and free.  
The heavy night with heavy haze  
Had been descending, but the blaze  
Of light and brilliance caught the steed,  
Betrayed her form, her frothing speed.

The *Duke*’s great turrets boldly spoke,  
Belched shell and fire, fume and smoke.  
Concussion tore the night around.  
The shells went screaming through the sound  
And landed close aboard the Hun,  
A “straddle” salvo number one.

The *Duke* corrected plot and range  
And there began a fierce exchange  
Of shell and suffering. *Scharnhorst* blazed  
Where blasts and flame her structures razed.  
She turned to east in panicked fright  
And sought the dark, descending night.

The *Duke* sped after, sending shell,  
Fired havoc, roaring hell  
Raining down upon the fleeing  
Battered, bruised and barely seeing  
Nazi supership which sped  
Ever more and more ahead.

At last the *Duke* had lost the range.  
Her guns were silenced, but a strange  
New battle lit the horizon’s edge  
And smote the *Scharnhorst* like a sledge.  
She reared and tossed and bellowed toward  
*Saumarez, Savage, Scorpion, Stord*.

She did not flee as fast, for they,  
More swiftly speeding on their way,  
O'ertook her and on either bow  
Engaged the bleeding *Scharnhorst* now.  
Her voice was wild, her aim was bad;  
She fought with all the guns she had.

At forty knots the destroyers came.  
Ten thousand yards, they took their aim;  
Six thousand yards, without a change  
Of course or speed they closed the range.  
Two thousand yards, they launched their dread  
Torpedoes, and away they sped.

The *Scharnhorst* snorted, scored a hit.  
*Saumarez* felt the blast of it.  
But then the launched torpedoes struck,  
And *Scharnhorst's* inner heart was stuck.  
Her guns began a wild, red fire,  
She'd lost her speed, could not retire.

By now the *Duke of York* had closed,  
And with another force composed  
Of *Sheffield*, *Norfolk*, and *Belfast*,  
*Jamaica*, and come up at last,  
Four escorts from the convoy screen,  
Began a new approach routine.

The *Scharnhorst* shuddered, shell on shell  
From eight destroyers upon her fell.  
From four crack cruisers she sustained  
The heavy, horrid fire they trained.  
Each salvo from the *Duke of York*  
Left her unsteady as a cork.

Around and round the battle raged,  
On every side she was engaged  
By greater force and stronger will,  
A broken thing of beauty still.

A broken ring of steady sun,  
And then the ships received command  
To stand well clear on every hand.

The battle paused. The night returned,  
And in that dark the *Scharnhorst* burned.  
The swift and final act began.  
*Jamaica* left the cruiser van  
And headed toward the trembling pile  
Where life and metal burned the while.

A neat destroyer trained her lights  
Upon the target and the sights  
Aboard *Jamaica*, set to kill,  
Could pledge the beast her final thrill.  
*Jamaica* swung. Torpedoes leapt,  
Their course and their appointment kept.

A last great roar the *Scharnhorst* gave,  
Then rolled her fires beneath the wave,  
A wretched, moving, dying thing  
Within the watchful naval ring.  
The black, salt sea her vitals drank,  
And, quenched her thirst, the *Scharnhorst* sank.

### *LITTLE BOYS AND LITTLE DOGS*

Little boys and little dogs  
Are made for one another.  
For show me, sir, a little dog  
Just taken from its mother  
That will not find a tenderness  
And clumsy kind of joy  
In the care, and taking care, of  
A loving little boy.



U.S.S. OKLAHOMA *RETURNS TO HER CREW*



We did not recognize her as she sank among us here,  
A wretched hulk, dismasted, disemboweled and stripped of gear.  
We did not recognize her. They were selling her for junk  
When she listed like a derelict, abandoned, wrecked, and sunk.

For we were sea-dead sailors wandering aimlessly the deep,  
Without a ship, without a bunk, without a place to sleep,  
For we were sea-dead sailors of a ship that killed us all  
When she rolled her weight upon us as the bombs began to fall.

We loved that ship. Her lines were trim, her speed was fleet and free,  
And when she joined maneuvers she was beautiful to see.  
That morning when torpedoes struck, with water, oil and blood  
She swiftly filled and overturned her masthead in the mud.

How long we lived, how long lay dead within her flooded sides  
Till all awakened, spirit-drifted, ebbing with the tides!  
Oh, some were brave but could not save the other, some afraid,  
And all upon a hillside we were later, gently laid.

We did not recognize her, for the ship we loved so well  
Had died with us that morning in the harbor's flaming Hell,  
And our remembrance was not this, a scrapped and broken hull  
That came among us timid as a shy and lonely gull.

We turned our backs upon her; she was not of our command,  
But suddenly a seaman with a flashlight in his hand  
Began to signal frantically. We turned and somehow knew  
She was the *Oklahoma* and she knew we were her crew.

We wept, we cried, we swarmed aboard, we kissed her weary decks,  
We made a thousand seaweed leis and hung them round our necks.  
We danced, we laughed; our salted eyes flowed tears without relief,  
For it was good to know at last the end of all her grief.

We built a superstructure, casemates, turrets, funnel, jack.  
We fitted out compartments and we put the galley back.  
We mustered on the quarterdeck and bowed our heads in thanks,

And mourned for those, our shipmates, who were missing from the ranks.

We stationed watch and quarters and we stowed our gear below.

We manned the bridge and sea-details, and rode the undertow.

Some evening in the sunset of a bright and happy day

We'll come steaming through the Golden Gate for San Francisco Bay!

### *NIGHT*

Night is a stricken bird whose breast is laid against the earth,

Whose broken wings both comfort and surround the compassed air.

Night is a fallen sparrow boys have stoned in spending small

Or token sums of their vast wealth's amazing cruelty.

Night is a stricken bird whose heart has throbbed against my own,

Whose broken wings have brushed my cheek, whose beak has hit my lip.

Night is a restless fellow gone to bed, who cannot sleep,

Yet will not rise to walk the parks and barter with desire.

Night is all the sewers of a frustrate mind

Spewing up positioned nudes inseminating one another!

## *FOR ALL HEROES*

Here are the guys who have died for the world,  
Died for the battles in which they were hurled,  
Died for the flags that have long since been furled,  
And on this cross, Christ!

Here are the bastard, expendable lot,  
Here are the laughs when the laughter is not,  
Here are the guys who are always forgot,  
And on this cross, Christ!

Look, you! Behold through the beard and the blood,  
The face of the lover inflamed with the crud;  
See the strong limbs that lie still in the mud.  
Look on the red lips that open no more.  
What does it matter by what gods they swore?  
War's the procurer and here lies his whore!  
What can you say to a guy when he's dead?  
Kneel down beside him, lift up his head?  
Thank what you thank it was not you instead?  
And on this cross?

God love you and keep you, you son of a bitch,  
Scratching your ass or wherever you itch,  
Restless in sleep as you jump and you twitch.  
Go, when you're called from your haunts and your sports;  
Go, be a number in battle's reports.  
Drown your desires and shoot in your shorts  
Take up your rifle and take up your clip,  
Take the canteen and water you'll sip.  
You've got a class that you don't want to skip,  
As on this cross, Christ!

*FOXHOLE*

Your nearness thundered through me and I shook,  
And when you said, "You're trembling." I said, "Yes."  
And then you asked, "Ya scared?" What could I say?  
We two had been together since the States  
And I had kept the bluff and we were friends.

Why, I remember how it was we met.  
We both were standing naked. You were soaped  
From head to foot and then the shower quit.  
I never heard a rhythmic stream of words  
So finely mouthed, and chewed and spitted out

But now we lie together in the sand  
Upon a tropic beach. The enemy,  
For all our air and sea and boasted might,  
Had held his little island and opposed  
Our coming with such surety of aim  
That half our comrades dropped face down, face up,  
And did not feel the black and blooded wash  
That played between their sprawled and spreaded legs.

We two were forward on the farthest flank  
That hoped to outmaneuver and destroy  
The deep pillbox entrenchment where the Nip  
Had taken his position and command  
Of all the open, dead-man beach between.  
We'd found a little dune and dug us in,  
And all the long tormented afternoon  
We lobbed our ineffectual grenades  
Against the fort foreknowledge of the Jap.

When night came on we got the word to hold,  
But silence and the darkness held us close  
And I could hear your breathing, feel you near.  
And then there went through me an echoing roar  
As when a mountainside of snow and ice  
Lets loose its frantic grip and tumbles down.  
And then you said "You're trembling " I said "Yes "

And then you said, "You're dreaming." I said, "Yes."  
You asked, "Ya scared?" And I said, "Yes," again.

The silence fell between us for a while.  
Your hand reached out and rudely grasped my arm.  
"You're lying, kid." Your grip was strong and fierce.  
You held me there as if to make me shout  
With pain or ecstasy, and time rushed by  
Unclocked. You shuddered then and let me go.  
"You're lying, kid, and so, sweet God, am I."

The blast of brilliance, flame and heat that came  
Exploding close beside us threw the sand,  
And shell, and death and you and me apart.  
How long we lay half buried none will tell  
I know I wakened somewhere near the dawn  
And saw you stretched and saw your trousers torn.  
I crawled beside you, brushed away the sand  
That filled your eyes. I held you in my arms,  
And pressed my mouth to yours as if my breath  
Within your lungs would bring your arms around me.  
I know I sobbed, and wept, and cursed, and prayed.  
My fevered hands I burned beneath your blouse  
To touch your unresponsive, frigid flesh.  
And then I knew that you were dead,  
    That you were dead,  
        That you were dead,  
            That we should lie no more!

*BURY HIM*



Bury him! Not where the rough, raw earth  
    With his fathers' bones is filled,  
Nor bury him there where the old chiefs' blood  
    On the rich, rolled plain is spilled,  
And bury him not where he'll be forgot,  
    With the reason for which he was killed,  
But, bury him. Bury him.

Bury him not in a lonely plot  
    In the midst of the fools who cried  
Of his race and his face, and forgot every trace  
    Of the reason for which he died,  
While the heart of the nation's demoralization  
    Began to ascend as it sighed,  
"Bury him. Bury him."

Bury him well. Let the bugler tell  
    To the listening wind and the wood  
How an Indian boy, who was somebody's joy  
    And the pride of a small neighborhood,  
Met his death in the yell of a Korean hell,  
    And, returned to his home, was accused  
Of his race and his place in a nation's disgrace,  
    And his burial there was refused.

Let the volley resound and the hollows be found  
    To re-echo the bugle and gun,  
Till the echoes grow dim and we know that in him  
    We bury all men in this one.  
For we bury the stain when we bury the slain  
    In these wars that are yet to be won.

Bury him, then, where such comrades shall lie  
    Side by side in the long marbled sleep,  
As have longed long for sleeping, and there in their keeping  
    Assign him the grave he shall keep.  
In that company of others, his spiritual brothers,  
    Whose tears all were salt when they'd ween



whose tears all were salt when they do weep.  
Bury him. Bury him.

Bury him mournfully, he who was scornfully  
Thought to be brought to disgrace among men.  
Bury heroically here all the stoically  
Suffered injustice and wrong that has been.  
Bury the dead and defeated, repeated  
Mistakes that have tumbled our honor again.  
Bury the past with its hate and its slaughter,  
And from this sweet grave make beginning. Come, then,  
Bury him! Bury him!

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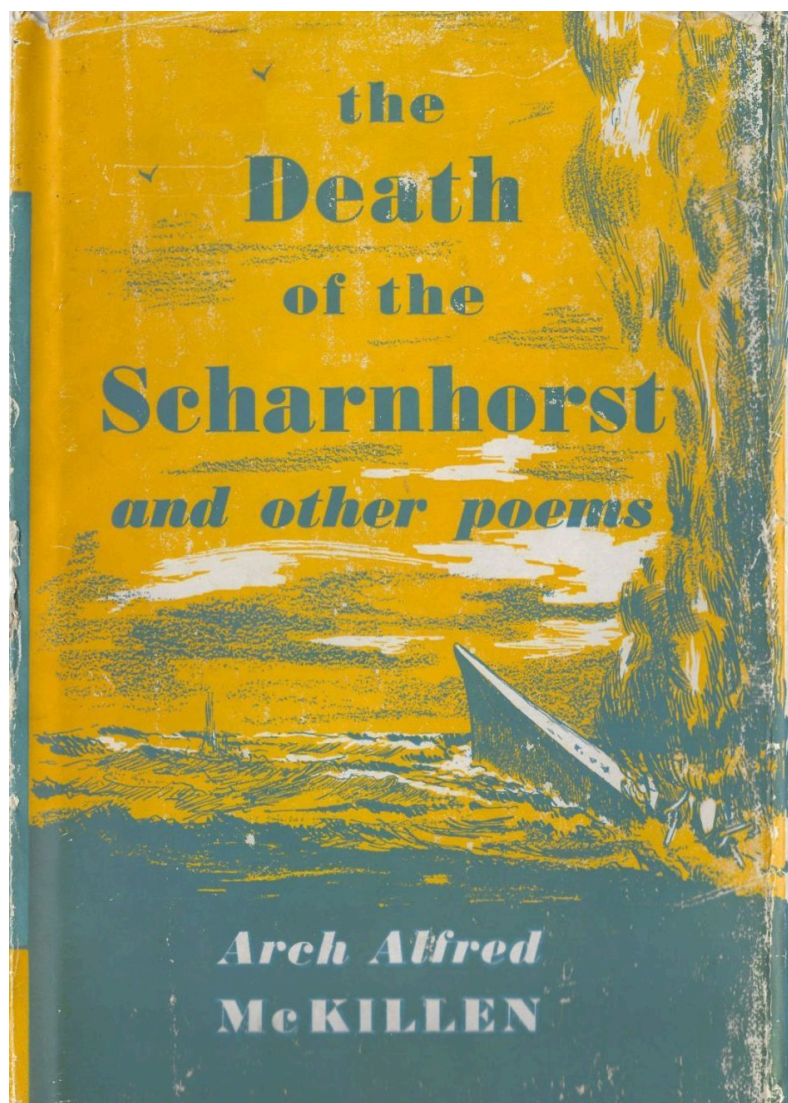
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